What Is Coaching?

Coaching as a way of helping people see their situation more clearly and find their own way forward, and the skills a coach keeps developing over time.

The purpose of coaching

Coaching supports individuals or teams to work better by helping them see their situation more clearly and change the habits, patterns and roles that hold them back. It is more than a toolbox or a set of techniques. It is also a way of acting, and that is usually harder to develop than knowledge about any particular subject.

Unlike teaching or advising, coaching happens in the context of the coachee, who does the larger part of the work. The coach does not hand over answers. The coachee finds answers that fit their own situation. This is also why coaching is such an important part of learning: it helps people take something they understand in general and apply it in their own context and environment.

How coaches develop

By coaching and by observing others coach, you build up your own collection of patterns and tools. A new coach relies on written material and the support of others. An experienced coach can quickly form and test hypotheses, pick the right tool for the situation and apply it.

To become a good coach, you need to learn to observe and listen, to keep your own biases under control, to avoid jumping to premature conclusions, and to communicate well. All of this affects how aware you are of yourself, how you react to other people and how others perceive you. It is one of the reasons coaches value feedback and supervision from other coaches.

A soft skill with a structure

Coaching is a soft skill, but a structured one, and a coaching engagement often stretches over months or even years. This makes it possible to define good practices, such as the coaching structure described later in this collection, that help a coach work deliberately rather than by instinct alone.

Coaching is not a matter of walking into an organisation, talking to a few people, running a workshop and expecting everything to change. It includes different types of activity, which the resource on coaching stances describes. To sharpen the picture of what coaching is, it also helps to compare it with other well-known kinds of coaching.

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Further reading

- Kimsey-House, H., Kimsey-House, K., Sandahl, P. and Whitworth, L.: Co-Active Coaching. A widely used introduction to coaching skills, from listening to powerful questions.
- Whitmore, J.: Coaching for Performance. A practical introduction to coaching in organisations and the origin of the GROW model.

Online version with links to related resources: https://resources.simsab.net/coaching-skills/what-is-coaching